



Cameroon



Situated in the corner of the Gulf of Guinea, Cameroon was effectively a one-party state for 30 years. Multiparty elections, since 1992, regularly return that same party to power.



GEOGRAPHY

Over half the land is forested: equatorial rainforest in north, evergreen forest and wooded savanna in south. Mountains in the west.



CLIMATE

South is equatorial, with plentiful rainfall, declining inland. Far north is beset by drought.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Around 230 ethnic groups; no single group is dominant. The Bamileke is the largest, though it has never held political power. North-south tensions are diminished by the ethnic diversity. There is more rivalry between majority French- and minority English-speakers.



INSIGHT: *Cameroon's name derives from the Portuguese word camarões, after the shrimp fished by the early European explorers*



THE ECONOMY

Oil reserves. Very diversified agricultural economy – timber, cocoa, bananas, coffee. Fuel smuggling from Nigeria undermines refinery profits. Corruption. Port for Chad and CAR.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Cameroon

DATE OF FORMATION: 1960

CAPITAL: Yaoundé

POPULATION: 19.5 million

TOTAL AREA: 183,567 sq. miles
(475,400 sq. km)

DENSITY: 109 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Bamileke, Fang, Fulani, French*, English*

RELIGIONS: Catholic 35%, traditional beliefs 25%, Muslim 22%, Protestant 18%

ETHNIC MIX: Highlanders 31%, other 39%, equatorial Bantu 19%, Kirdi 11%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: CFA franc = 100 centimes